The Fourteenth Amendment

Ratified July 9, 1868

Source: U.S. Constitution, Amendment XIV, Section 1 (1868). Public domain.

> The centerpiece of Reconstruction: it made the formerly enslaved citizens and guaranteed all persons “due process” and “equal protection of the laws” — the constitutional foundation for a century of later civil rights rulings.

All persons born or naturalized in the United States, and subject to the jurisdiction thereof, are citizens of the United States and of the state wherein they reside. No state shall make or enforce any law which shall abridge the privileges or immunities of citizens of the United States; nor shall any state deprive any person of life, liberty, or property, without due process of law; nor deny to any person within its jurisdiction the equal protection of the laws.